prison in the mid-1920s, he contacted Bhagat Singh and then himself started participating in HSRA politics. In that introduction, Bhagat Singh explained, ‘Revolution necessarily implies the programme of systematic reconstruction of society on new and better adopted basis, after complete destruction of the existing state of affairs . . .’.[11] He suggested, ‘We revolutionaries are striving to capture power in our hands and to organise a revolutionary government which should employ all its resources for mass education, as is being done in Russia today. After capturing power, peaceful methods shall be employed for constructive work, force shall be employed to crush the obstacles.’[12] Noting that Lala Ram Saran Das had highlighted in his book the ‘giving of alms to those in need’, Bhagat Singh tersely added the corrective, ‘In the future society, i.e. the communist society that we want to build, we are not going to establish charitable institutions, and no alms-giving and alms-taking.’ Instead, there will be available for all of India’s children a ‘free education’ and this is because ‘the socialist government has adopted somewhat the same course in Russia’.

What Bhagat Singh and his comrades had awakened to, therefore, was a world of limitless possibilities where a new world would be carved out of the present, a world transformed. He advocated a complete political reformation, pointing out how ‘[c]rime is the most serious social problem which needs a very tactful treatment’ so that, ‘instead of retribution, i.e. retaliation, the reformative theory should form the basis of punishment. Not to punish but to reclaim should be the guiding principle of the administration of justice. Jails should be reformatories and not veritable hells’. How revolutionary this must have sounded in a colonized land where jails were the lynchpin of a system of oppression by the state. And yet, Bhagat Singh did not hesitate to make the call. As for war, he believed it would become redundant ‘because in that society there shall be no conflicting or diverse interests that cause war’. If necessary, ‘war shall have to be retained as an institution for the transitional period’ only. This is because